

Session 17: Jacob Deceives His Deceiver

Key Takeaways

- Yaaqov and Lavan each try to gain the upper hand over the other. As their wealth increases, so does the tension between them.
- A likely explanation for Yaaqov's use of the rods with the sheep is that they act as artificial mating partners to control which rams are able to successfully mate.
- Yaaqov's use of animal disguises fits a developing pattern of deceit in Genesis.

Lavan the Snake Curses To Get the Blessing

²⁵ And it came about when Rakhel had borne Joseph,
and Yaaqov said to Lavan,

“Send me away,
that I may go to my own place and to my own land.

²⁶ **Give** me my wives and my children for whom I have **served** you, that I may go,
for you yourself know my service which I have served you.”

²⁷ And Lavan said to him,
“If I have found favor in your eyes,
I have learned by divination
that **Yahweh has blessed me on account of you.”**

²⁸ And he said,
“Name me **your wages**,
and **I will give it.”**

²⁹ And he said to him,
“**You yourself know how I have served you**
and how your cattle have been with me,
³⁰ for you had little before I came
and it has **broken out** to a multitude,
and Yahweh has blessed you at my foot.
And now, when may I act for my own household also?”

Genesis 30:25-30. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

Now that Yaaqov has worked as Lavan’s slave for 14 years, we learn that Lavan has consulted his gods through divination and learned something true: All abundance and fruitfulness is a gift of Yahweh, the *Elohim* of Yaaqov.

Importantly, Lavan reveals just how he came by this knowledge.

Genesis 30:27 NASB
I have learned by divination (Heb. *nakhash* / נחש) that Yahweh has blessed me on account of you.

The word for “knowledge gained by divination” (*nakhash*) is spelled with the same three letters (= is a homonym) as the Hebrew word for snake (*nakhash*)!

Lavan’s household flourishes under Yaaqov’s care, and Lavan knows its true source. Will Lavan let his golden boy go home?

The Nations and the Blessing

Notice this portrait of Lavan’s desire to benefit from Yaaqov’s blessing and how it contrasts with Yaaqov’s father Yitskhaq and grandfather Abraham. This all began with the programmatic statement that God made to Abraham, and was then repeated to Yaaqov by Yitskhaq.

Genesis 12:3 NASB
And I will bless those who bless you,
and the one who treats you as cursed (מקלל) I will curse (ארר).
And in you all the families of the earth will be blessed.

Genesis 27:29 NASB
May peoples serve you,
and may people groups bow down to you,
be a mighty one to your brothers,
and may the sons of your mother bow down to you.
Cursed (ארר) are those who curse (ארר) you,
and those who blessed you are blessed.

Abraham and Avimelek	Yitskhaq and Avimelek	Jacob and Laban
Gen. 20 Abraham deceives Avimelek regarding Sarah his wife	Gen. 26 Yitskhaq deceives Avimelek regarding his wife	Gen. 29 Laban deceives Jacob regarding his daughter
Gen. 21:22-34 Avimelek comes to Abraham in peace	Gen. 26:14-16 The Philistines are envious of Jacob, so Avimelek	Gen. 30:27-28 And Laban said to Jacob,

Patriarchal Promises in Genesis. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

Abraham and Avimelek	Yitskhaq and Avimelek	Jacob and Laban
"I see that Elohim is with you in all that you are doing. Now, swear an oath to me by Elohim ..."	says, "Go away from us, for you are too powerful!" Gen. 26:28 But later he comes back to Yitskhaq and says, "We see that Yahweh has been with you, and we said 'Let there now be an oath between us, between you and us, and let us make a covenant with you!'"	"If I have found favor in your eyes, I have learned by divination that Yahweh has blessed me on account of you. ... Now then, mark your wages and I will give it."
<i>Patriarchal Promises in Genesis. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).</i>		

Notice the variety of responses.

- Abimelech with Abraham: Positive recognition of Yahweh's blessing > desire for a covenant
- Abimelech with Yitskhaq: Negative reaction, followed by a positive recognition of Yahweh's blessing > desire for covenant
- Lavan with Yaaqov: Seemingly positive recognition of Yahweh's blessing > no desire for a covenant, but instead negotiation about a deal: "Mark your wages."

The phrase "mark your wages" uses an uncommon Hebrew word: *noqbah* / נקבה, from the root *naqab* / נקב, which means "to pierce, mark."

- This root (*naqab*) is a by-form (a homonym) of another Hebrew root, *qabab* / קבב, and both mean "to mark for a curse." (See Lev. 24:11, 16; Job 3:8; Prov. 11:26 where it is spelled *qiqqob* / יקב, ironically the main letters of Yaaqov's name יעקב!)
- This root (קבב often spelled יקב, which looks like how נקב is spelled when it means "marked as cursed") is one of the main Hebrew words for "curse" (קבב) that is used in the Balaam narratives in Numbers 22-24. And low and behold, it shows a remarkable number of hyperlinks with the stories of Yitskhaq and Abimelech and Yaaqov and Lavan!

Numbers 22:5-6, 11, 17 NASB*

⁵ So [the king of Moab] sent messengers to Balaam the son of Beor, at Pethor, which is near the River, in the land of the sons of his people, to call him, saying, "Behold, a people came out of Egypt; behold, they cover the surface of the land, and they are living opposite me. ⁶ Now, therefore, please come, **curse (אָרַר)** this people for me since **they are too powerful for me;** perhaps I may be able to defeat them and drive them out of the land. For I know that **he whom you bless is blessed, and he whom you curse (אָרַר) is cursed (אָרַר).**"

¹¹ "Behold, there is a people who came out of Egypt and they cover the surface of the land; now come, **curse (קַבַּב)** them for me; perhaps I may be able to fight against them and drive them out."

¹⁷ “for I will indeed honor you richly, and I will do whatever you say to me. Please come then, **curse** (קבב) this people for me.”

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Numbers 23:7-8, 11, 25-26 NASB*

⁷ He took up his discourse and said, “From Aram Balak has brought me, Moab’s king from the mountains of the East, ‘Come **curse** (ארר) Yaaqov for me, And come, denounce Israel!’ ⁸ How shall I **curse** (קבב) whom God has not **cursed** (קבב)? ...”

¹¹ Then Balak said to Balaam, “What have you done to me? I took you to **curse** (קבב) my enemies, but behold, you have actually **blessed** them!”

²⁵ Then Balak said to Balaam, “Do not **curse** (קב לא תקבנו) them at all nor **bless** them at all!” ²⁶ But Balaam replied to Balak, “Did I not tell you, ‘Whatever the Lord speaks, that I must do’?”

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Numbers 24:9-10 NASB*

⁹ “He couches, he lies down as a lion, and as a lion, who dares rouse him? **Blessed** is everyone who **blesses** you, and **cursed** (ארר) is everyone who **curses** (ארר) you.” ¹⁰ Then Balak’s anger burned against Balaam, and he struck his hands together; and Balak said to Balaam, “I called you to **curse** (קבב) my enemies, but behold, you have persisted in blessing them these three times!”

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

These narratives lay out a program, a foundational statement, for the role of God’s chosen, blessed one among the nations. Some nations quickly recognize God’s chosen ones and enter into the covenant and discover God’s blessing: Eshkol and Aner the Canaanites (Gen. 14), Abimelech (Gen. 21 and 26). Others don’t care and oppress God’s chosen ones (Pharaoh in Exod. 1, Balak king of Moab in Num. 22-24).

Others take a while to come around, like Abimelech in Genesis 26 and Lavan in Genesis 30. Abimelech wants to reject God’s chosen one but eventually comes around. Lavan wants to mooch off of the blessing of Yaaqov but finds himself deceived and cheated just as he did to Yaaqov!

Paragraph 2: Genesis 30:31-36

³¹ And he said,
“**What shall I give you?**”

And Yaaqov said,

“**You will not give me anything.**

If you will do this thing for me,

I will again **shepherd** and keep **your flock**:

³² Let me pass through your entire flock **today**,

removing from there

every speckled and spotted lamb
and every dark one among the male-sheep
and the spotted and speckled among the she-goats;
and it shall be my wage.

³³ And my righteousness will answer for me on a following day ,
when you go over my wage before you,
every one that is not speckled and spotted among the she-goats
and dark among the male-sheep with me,
will be considered stolen.”

³⁴ And Lavan said,
“Behold, let it be according to your word.”

³⁵ And he [= Lavan] removed on that day
the striped and spotted male goats
and all the speckled and spotted female goats,
every one with white [= laban] in it,
and all the black ones among the sheep,
and gave them into the care of his sons.

³⁶ And he put a journey of three days between himself and Yaaqov,
and as for Yaaqov, he shepherded the rest of Lavan’s flocks.

Genesis 30:31-36. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

Paragraph 3: Genesis 30:37-43

³⁷ And Yaaqov took rods of poplar [=lebenah] ,
fresh, as well as almond and plane,
and he peeled white (laban) stripes in them,
exposing the white (laban) on the rods.

³⁸ And he placed the rods which he had peeled
by the troughs ,
by the water-troughs where the flocks came to drink,
in front of the flock,
and they mated when they came to drink.

³⁹ And the flocks mated with/upon the rods,
and the flocks gave birth to striped , speckled , and spotted .

40 And the lambs Yaaqov separated,
and he made the **flocks** face toward the **striped** and all the **black** in the **flock** of **Lavan** ;
and he **placed** his own herds apart,
and he did not **place** them with **Lavan's flock**.

41 And it came about in all the **mating** of **the strong ones** of the **flock**,
Yaaqov would place the **rods**
in the sight of the flock
in the troughs ,
so that they would **mate** with the **rods** ;
42 and when the **flock** was **weak** ,
he did not place them
and the **weak ones** belonged to **Lavan**
and the **strong ones** belonged to Yaaqov.

43 And the **man broke** out very much,
and there belonged to him **many flocks**,
and female and male **servants**,
and camels and donkeys.

Genesis 30:37-43. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

Of Speckled Sheep and Mating Rods

This story is a detailed explanation of how Yaaqov eventually gets the upper hand over his deceptive uncle. He puts himself in what seems to be a vulnerable situation, but then he uses an ancient animal breeding trick to produce a large flock for himself. However, exactly what Yaaqov does with his flocks is a matter of debate among scholars because the story's vocabulary and narrative are difficult to understand.

For the discussion that follows, see Scott Noegel's "[Sex, Sticks, and Tricksters in Genesis 30:31-43: A New Look at an Old Crux](#)" in *Journal of the Ancient Near Eastern Society*, vol. 25 (1997), p. 7-17.

A common explanation says Yaaqov uses the rods mentioned [Gen. 30:37-42](#) in either a superstitious ritual or as an aphrodisiac to incite the mating of the correctly colored animals.

"[Jacob acts] on the common belief that a vivid sight during pregnancy or conception would leave its mark on the embryo."

Kidner, Derek (2008). [Genesis \(Tyndale Old Testament Commentaries\)](#). IVP Academic. 163.

There are two main problems with this explanation.

1. All evidence of this strange belief in Jewish culture dates to the 5th century A.D. and later—over 1,500 years later than the time of Yaaqov!

2. If the sticks were some kind of aphrodisiac, this does not explain why he places the rods out when the “strong ones” of Lavan’s flock were mating (30:41-42.) If they induce mating and fertility, we would expect the opposite.

The more likely explanation says the sticks were placed as “false mating partners.”

- Genesis 30:39 says in Hebrew that “the flock mated against/upon the rods (אל המקלות).”
- Genesis 30:41 says in Hebrew “the flock mated with the rods (במקלות).”

“[T]he passage depicts Jacob employing the poplar rods not as a fertility symbol or aphrodisiac, but rather as a type of ‘fake phallus.’ That is, Jacob allowed only the animals which he did not want to sire offspring to ‘become heated upon the rods.’ Herders and veterinarians acquainted with the breeding patterns of sheep and goats are well-aware that while female lambs are in heat, they are often inclined to rub their genitals on trees or sticks ... Like Jacob in Gen. 30:40, animal breeders often employ artificial mating devices along with ‘teaser animals,’ i.e., males introduced into the flock to induce the females into early heat. This practice is precisely what Jacob exploits in Gen. 30:39-41.”

Noegel, Scott B. (1997). “Sex, Sticks, and the Trickster in Gen. 30:31-43: A New Look at an Old Crux.” *Journal of Ancient Near Eastern Society*, vol. 25. 10.

The sequence of the narrative, while difficult to follow, makes more sense once we see that the rods function as artificial mating devices.

1. In Genesis 30:32, Yaaqov requests that his wages consist of: (a) “every speckled and spotted lamb,” (b) “every dark among the male-lambs,” and (c) “every spotted and speckled she-goat.”
 - Later in the narrative, we learn that some of Yaaqov's own flocks are already oddly colored (30:40). Here, Yaaqov proposes that the oddly colored ones among Lavan’s flock will belong to himself.
 - Yaaqov's named wage still leaves among Lavan’s flock (a & b) the speckled, spotted, and dark female lambs (“ewes”), and (c) all the spotted and speckled male-goats.
2. In Gen. 30:35, Lavan removes from his own flock (not from Yaaqov's, see 30:40) all the goats that might produce speckled, spotted, and dark young for Yaaqov. This includes: (a) striped and spotted he-goats, (b) speckled and spotted she-goats, (c) every goat with white on it, and (d) every dark sheep.
3. In Genesis 30:36, Lavan puts the distance of three days between his own flocks and Yaaqov who is now caring for Yaaqov's flock. This is Lavan’s newest attempt to cheat Yaaqov. He is removing the animals that would, under natural circumstances, be used for breeding the animals that Yaaqov has named as his wages.
4. In Genesis 30:37, Yaaqov creates mating sticks out of three kinds of aromatic trees (poplar, almond, plane), which exude a milky substance when peeled. Notice the wordplay and intentional irony: The sticks which Yaaqov uses to cheat Lavan (לבן) are themselves the color of “white” (= Hebrew *Lavan* / לבן).
5. In Genesis 30:38, Yaaqov places the sticks “by/on the *rehatim* (רהטים), by the watering troughs where the females of the flock came to drink, facing the flock, and they mated when the females came to drink.”
 - Given the make up of the flock left to Yaaqov in 30:35, the only female animals this can refer to are the speckled and spotted female lambs and the striped and dark she-goats.
 - The rare noun *rehatim* could mean “trough” (as in Exod. 2:16), but a cognate noun is also used in Song of Songs 7:6 to describe flowing hair, which could make good sense here: it would mean

that Yaaqov is creating fake male sheep and goats with “rods” to mate with that will produce no offspring.

6. In Genesis 30:39, we’re told that the flocks mate “against/upon the rods” and “the flocks bore striped, speckled, and spotted.” Since the animals give birth to striped, speckled, and spotted young, the animals that mated on the poplar rods must have been Lavan’s dark she-goats. They, of course, did not bear any offspring. Conversely, only the few speckled and spotted female lambs, and the striped goats that were not placed near the rods, bring forth young. From these, Yaaqov takes for himself the spotted and speckled female lambs and he-goats (as he said in Gen. 30:32).
7. In Genesis 30:40, Yaaqov separates the speckled and spotted sheep that belong to him, and “made them face the striped and all the dark ones in the flock of Lavan.” That is, he uses his female lambs and mates them with Lavan’s male lambs of the same color. He exploits Lavan’s striped and dark sheep to produce his own wages.
8. In Genesis 30:41-42, Yaaqov distinguishes among Lavan’s flock between the sheep that breed early (“the strong”) and those that breed late (“the weak”), and he allows only the strong to mate against the rods, thus producing no young. However, when his own flocks were drinking (as 30:42 implies) Yaaqov did not set out the rods, so that “the weak ones belong to Lavan and the strong ones to Yaaqov.”

Conclusion: Yaaqov uses a subtle, deceptive technique to make sure his own animals multiply while Lavan’s slowly dwindle.

Yaaqov Among the Deceivers in Genesis

Yaaqov's use of “animal disguises” and perhaps even “flowing hair” (the *rehotim* in Gen. 30:38, 41) fits into a larger motif in the Genesis scroll, where characters use “animal deceptions” to accomplish their plans.

- The animal skin used by Yaaqov to impersonate Esau (Gen. 27:16).
- The goat’s blood smeared on the coat by Joseph’s brothers (Gen. 37:31).
- Tamar, who gets Judah to promise her a young goat so she can rescue the promised lineage by sleeping with her father-in-law (Gen. 38:17, 23).

Yaaqov's “mating rods” also connect to Leah’s “mandrakes” in the previous literary unit. Both are “fertile items of irony.”

“The mandrakes are eaten by the barren Rachel, but it is Leah who conceives. The rods perform a similar function. They are meant to inspire Laban’s herds to copulate, but to no effect ... Jacob's manipulation of Laban’s flocks also mirrors Laban’s deception of Jacob in 29:21-30. Just as Laban deceives Jacob in receiving the older Leah (lit. ‘Calf’) instead of younger Rachel (lit. ‘Female Lamb’) as a wife, so now it is the ‘stronger’ of Laban’s flocks which Jacob places before the impotent rods.”

Noegel, Scott B. (1997). “Sex, Sticks, and the Trickster in Gen. 30:31-43: A New Look at an Old Crux.” *Journal of Ancient Near Eastern Society*, vol. 25. 14-15.

Lavan’s deception of Yaaqov and Yaaqov's counter-deception aimed at acquiring many goats and sheep stand in contrast to Abraham, who trusted Yahweh to provide the “lamb” as a substitute in the ‘*aqedah*’ of Genesis 22. In that story, the animal stands in the place of the human Yitskhaq.

- Lavan removes all the striped (עקד) sheep (שה) and goats (Gen. 30:32, 35, 39, 40; 31:8, 10). This is the only appearance of this rare Hebrew root word in Genesis, except for the once verbal root “bind” (עקד) in Genesis 22:9, where Abraham prepares Yitskhaq as the sacrificial “lamb” (שה)!
- Genesis 30:36: Lavan sends the “striped” (עקד) flocks away with his sons a journey of “three days.” (שלשת ימים) // Abraham and his son travel for “three days” without a lamb, before Abraham “binds” (עקד) his son.
- Genesis 30:38: Yaaqov places the poplar rods in the water trough (שקת) as his scheme to increase his flocks. // Avraham’s servant in Genesis 24:21 meets Rivqah at the water trough (שקת) and allows God to provide her as a wife. This is a contrast between Yaaqov's scheme and Abraham and his servant's trust in God's provision.

Yaaqov's deception of Lavan regarding his flock leads us back to the Genesis 3 deception, by linking together the motifs of sibling rivalry and the deception of the firstborn.

Genesis 30:25-43: Yaaqov Deceives Lavan of His Flock	Hyperlinks in Genesis
Gen. 30:27 “I have learned by divination (נחשתי) that Yahweh has blessed me because of you.”	Gen. 3:1 The snake (נחש) resents that God has elevated humans to a place of rule over the beasts.
Gen. 30:37 “And Yaaqov took for himself a staff of fresh poplar and almond wood and plane tree (ערמון)”	Gen. 3:1 “Now the snake was more shrewd (ערום) than any beast of the field”
Gen. 30:40 “And the lambs Yaaqov separated (פרד < הפריד), he gave the flocks to face the spotted.”	The פרד / separation of brothers motif in Genesis Gen. 2:10 Separation of the Eden waters Gen. 10:5, 32 Separation of the sons of Noah Gen. 13:9, 11, 14 Abram and Lot separate (הפרד) because of their flocks. Gen. 25:23 Yaaqov and Esau separate from the womb
Gen. 30:32, 39-42 The puns on the sheep that are “hot” (חום) and who “mate/are in heat” (חום).	Gen. 10:5, 32 Ham (חם) the son of Noah that “separates” from his brothers
Connecting Yaaqov's Deception and Genesis 3. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).	

Reflection Question

Yaaqov claims that his “righteousness will answer” for him in the deal he makes with Lavan for the flocks (Gen. 30:33). Do Yaaqov's actions demonstrate righteousness?